

Aix galericulata

Mandarin duck



Length 16–19½ in (41–49 cm)
Weight 22 oz (625 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location N.W. Europe, E. Asia



The male mandarin duck in its breeding plumage is among the most ornate and beautiful of all birds. It has a prominent crest on its head, golden hackles, and a pair of usually bright yellow, sail-shaped feathers on each inner wing. These can be erected above the flanks—their function is purely ornamental. Females and nonbreeding males are mostly olive-brown. This is one of the most arboreal of all ducks, often roosting or perching on branches and nesting in tree cavities; ducklings have to jump from the nest hole to the ground at only one day old. Like other perching ducks, its claws are sharp, to help it cling to branches, and its tail is

long and broad, acting as a brake to slow the duck down before it lands in the trees. It also has very large eyes, which help it see at night. The mandarin duck feeds on land, in the trees, and in water, where it dabbles, up-ends, and only rarely dives. Its diet consists of seeds and nuts, as well as some invertebrates, such as insects and land snails. Courtship is highly social, with several males competing for a female's attention. Originally from East Asia, introduced birds have established themselves in Western Europe.



Cairina moschata

Muscovy duck



Length 26–33 in (66–84 cm)
Weight 4½–8¾ lb (2–4 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern

Location Central America to C. South America



This large, heavy-bodied duck is mostly blackish as an adult (brownish black when young), and has a long tail, broad wings, and sharply clawed toes—all

adaptations for perching in trees. The adult male also has a slight crest on the top of the head, a knob above the nostrils, and bare, warty skin around the eyes. Domesticated birds (below) show many color variants. Unlike most ducks, both sexes are nearly mute.



Polysticta stelleri

Steller's eider



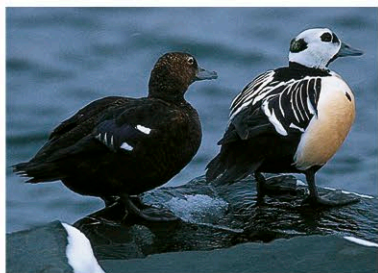
Length 17–18½ in (43–47 cm)
Weight 23–32 oz (650–900 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Migrant
Status Vulnerable

Location N.W. North America, N. Europe, N.E. Asia



This is the smallest of the 4 eider species, and the only one with an orange-rust breast and underparts (breeding males only). Its gray bill, which has soft, flaplike margins on each

side, is probably adapted for scraping invertebrates off rocks, or may serve as a tactile device when foraging in deep, dark waters. It lives entirely in the open sea except during the breeding season, when it may be observed in coastal waters, just before building its nest in low, grassy tundra.



Hymenolaimus malacorhynchos

Blue duck



Length 21 in (53 cm)
Weight 28–32 oz (775–900 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Endangered

Location New Zealand



Unique among waterfowl for its slate-blue plumage, this duck is highly adapted for life in cold, clear, rapidly flowing streams, where few other birds can survive. Its main food is the aquatic larvae of insects such as



caddisflies, mayflies, stoneflies, and midges, which it obtains by diving. It also feeds by dabbling at the surface, up-ending, and foraging around the riverbed rocks and boulders, where it uses its unique bill to scrape wet algae from the rocks.

Merganetta armata

Torrent duck



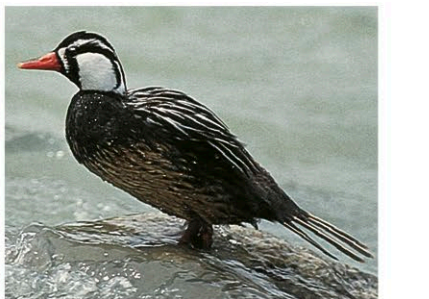
Length 17–18 in (43–46 cm)
Weight 16 oz (450 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern

Location W. South America



This highly streamlined, Andean duck never leaves rapid mountain streams, a habitat that few other ducks are able to exploit owing to the swiftness of the currents—the blue duck of New

Zealand (see above) is its closest ecological counterpart. It dives and swims upstream, remaining very close to the bottom, probing under rocks and among stones for insect larvae and pupae. Females are rufous, while males are black and white.



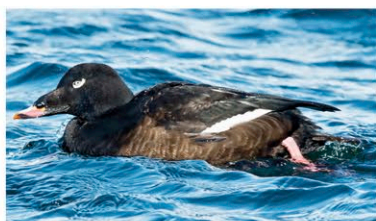
Melanitta deglandi

White-winged scoter



Length 20–23 in (51–58 cm)
Weight 3¼–4½ lb (1.5–2 kg)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location N.W., W., and E. North America, Europe, W., N., and E. Asia



Closely related to the velvet scoter, the white-winged scoter spends much of the year at sea, although it breeds on freshwater inland, and sometimes winters on large lakes. It forages by diving to depths of up to 23 ft (7 m), often remaining underwater for nearly a minute, or longer in deeper waters. It is a stout duck, with a heavy bill adapted for eating mollusks. Its large nostrils may be related to well-developed glands that excrete salts from any seawater that it swallows.

Mergus merganser

Common merganser



Length 23–26 in (58–66 cm)
Weight 3¼–4½ lb (1.5–2 kg)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location North America, Europe (including Iceland), Asia



One of the swiftest of all waterfowl, and the largest of the 5 species of fish-eating mergansers, this duck has a streamlined body that is adapted for rapid underwater swimming and flight—its air speed may approach 60 mph (100 kph). It has a long, narrow, serrated bill to catch and hold slippery fish, which form the main part of its diet. Females are mostly gray above, while males have black backs.

